

Assignment: Kill Your Darlings: Curate Your Images

1. Portfolio Image Map & Keepers

Asset Category	Content Map Need	Source & Asset Call	Description / Rationale
Hero Visual	Abstract technical framing for the landing page header.	AI Generated (hero-texture.png)	Subtle, low-contrast dark grid geometry using palette #2B3A42 and #3D7A8C. Acts as quiet connective tissue without stealing focus.
Profile Photo	About section / Personal identity frame.	Real Photo (shoaib-headshot.jpg)	Unprocessed real headshot. Per track guidelines: real human representation build trust over synthetic avatars.
Project 1: Jira Clone	Primary case study feature proof (Board & Workflow).	Real Capture (jira-clone-board.png)	High-resolution cropped screenshot of the Next.js app interface showing active Kanban columns and interactive UI state.

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Project 2: E-Commerce	Secondary case study proof (Checkout & Stripe flow).	Real Capture (ecommerce-stripe-checkout.png)	Clean browser crop showing the live webhook/checkout response flow and product interface.
Project 3: CV Maker	Short-form project card (Interactive form).	Real Capture (cv-maker-editor.png)	Clean screenshot focusing on the real-time form inputs and live dynamic preview rendering.
UI Iconography	Micro-visuals for tech stack tags (React, Next.js, Node).	Clean SVG Vectors (stack-icons/)	Standard flat SVG logos rendered strictly in #161A1D and #3D7A8C to maintain system cohesion.

2. Rejection Note: Discernment & Curation

- **Rejected Visual:** AI-generated 3D glassmorphism isometric illustrations for project thumbnails (jira-clone-3d-mockup.png).
- **Why it was rejected:** The generated 3D visual looked slick in isolation, but it felt like decorative fluff that upstaged the actual software. It hid the real UI density of the Next.js application behind generic studio lighting and exaggerated depth-of-field.
- **The Call:** Dropped the glossy synthetic render in favor of a flat, crisp 1:1 real application screenshot. A portfolio built on engineering rigor requires actual code and interface proof, not stylized AI concept art.

3. Grounding Decisions: Real Captures Over AI

1. **Software Proof:** All case studies utilize direct browser captures rather than AI-generated UI wireframes or polished device mockups. Real DOM elements, authentic typography density, and actual working UI states provide non-negotiable proof of competence.
2. **Personal Identity:** Used a real camera photograph for the headshot instead of an AI-generated professional headshot. Synthetic personal photos create immediate distrust in an engineering context.